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ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

SAND replenishment continues Monday on Long Beach's peninsula, where high surf has eroded the beach.

Observers will swarm the polls on election day

Both major parties and federal monitors make plans amid Trump's fraud claims.

BY STEVE PEOPLES AND ALI SWENSON

NEW YORK — Democrats and outside watchdogs are planning a massive presence at the polls on election day, driven by concerns that President Trump will further leverage the vast resources of the federal government to interfere with a midterm that could hobble his final two years in office.

They won't be the only ones there. A sprawling election protection effort on the left that is expected to deploy tens of thousands of monitors will be met by the largest-ever monitoring program by the Justice Department and still more observers from Republican-aligned groups. The result could be unlike anything seen at the polls in modern times.

The effort among Democratic and nonprofit groups includes training volunteers to stand watch outside polling places and report activities they consider concerning. The network includes traditional government watchdogs such as Common Cause and the American Civil Liberties Union plus a flood of volunteers assembled by state Democratic parties, congressional leaders, national activist groups and organizations focused on protecting democracy.

The Democratic National Committee created a first-of-its-kind cybersecurity unit staffed by former CIA and FBI officials to monitor and report online misinformation, including artificial intelligence deepfakes, said Jane Kleeb, vice chair of the DNC.

That's as Democratic mayors, attorneys general and secretaries of state host tabletop exercises simulating worst-case scenarios, such as a surge of Immigration and Customs Enforcement officials at voting locations or the seizure of ballots and voting equipment.

On Capitol Hill, Democratic leaders have assembled a legal team that rivals that of any presidential campaign.

"We've never done this before," Kleeb said of the party's sweeping efforts. But "we've never had to deal with

[See **Monitors,** A6]

Vote puts Israeli leader's legacy on the line

Netanyahu could be ultimate survivor, or his defeat could bring a new political era.

BY JOSEF FEDERMAN

JERUSALEM — When Hamas-led militants attacked Israel on Oct. 7, 2023, it looked as if Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's days in office were numbered.

With the country overwhelmed by grief and anger after the deadliest security breakdown in its history, his resignation seemed like a matter of time.

But the divisive veteran Israeli leader has scratched, scraped and literally battled his way back during a stormy three-year period of nonstop domestic crises and wars across the region. Confounding his critics, he now finds himself in a tight race for reelection Tuesday.

Netanyahu has been the country's most dominant politician for nearly two decades, and his legacy is on the line. A poor showing could end the 77-year-old's lengthy career on a bitter note and open the door to a new era in Israeli politics. A victory would cement his image as the ultimate political survivor.

Former Prime Minister Ehud Olmert, a onetime ally turned rival of Netanyahu, said there has never been so much at stake — from national security to the future of Israel's democratic institutions and its standing in the world. After a series of wars that have destabilized the region and jolted the global economy, the world is watching closely.

Politicians often say the current election is the most fateful in their country's history, Olmert said, but "this time it really is."

Netanyahu's opponents, led by former military chief Gadi Eisenkot, see Tuesday as a day of reckoning. They say Netanyahu should be held accountable for Oct. 7 and the failure to turn battlefield victories into diplomatic achievements.

"What he is offering is an eternal war," Eisenkot, whose son and two nephews were killed in combat, said in a radio interview. "Choosing a leader whose only goal is not to surrender means choosing a leader who will not deliver victories."

Netanyahu's supporters say that he was betrayed by Israel's defense establishment and that he has led the country through a remarkable turnaround with devastating strikes against Hamas, Lebanon's Hezbollah and Iran.

[See **Israel,** A3]

SoCal coast's current enemy: A hot ocean

Record-high water temperatures from El Niño are driving higher sea levels

BY RONG-GONG LIN II AND HANNAH FRY

Unprecedented flooding is quickly becoming a fact of life in some Southern California coastal communities.

On Monday morning, high tide brought water pouring into business districts in Newport Beach and flooded part of Pacific Coast Highway in Sunset Beach. Sea levels reached a record high in San Pedro, topping 8 feet. Conditions are expected to get worse Tuesday.

What's going on? After all, Southern California has endured El Niños before, as well as unusually high tides.

The difference, scientists say, comes to how hot the ocean waters have been. Hot water takes up more room than colder water, causing sea levels to rise. This week — even without any former hurricanes in the Pacific Ocean to send swells to the California coast — maximum sea levels recorded at high tide are nearly 2 feet higher than what would be expected from just astronomical forces that bring us high tides.

"The waters along the immediate coast of California are actually at record warm levels for the time of year, all the way from about the Farallon Islands south to Baja California," UC Agricultural and Natural Resources climate scientist Daniel Swain said in an interview Monday.

Because hot water raises sea levels, "the thermal expansion right now is comparable to, or even greater than, [what] we've really ever seen before of the seawater," Swain said. "That's starting to be a pretty significant elevation of sea level that has both direct and indirect contributions from El Niño, plus the background warming of the ocean."

An analysis of data posted to the website CyclonicWx shows that sea surface temperatures are at record-high levels off the California coast, as well as off the coast of the

[See **Enemy,** A14]

Misconduct claims jolt race

Accusations against Rep. Gomez of L.A. fuel momentum for DSA-backed rival.

BY DAKOTA SMITH

Rep. Jimmy Gomez's reelection bid, once helped by his high-profile fight against President Trump's immigration policies, is in peril as he tries to recover from allegations of sexual misconduct.

The accusations, which Gomez denies, have left the 51-year-old Eagle Rock Democrat vulnerable to an upstart challenger from Highland Park who earned a reputation for antagonism while serving on the area's neighborhood council.

Angela Gonzales-Torres, 31, is seizing on Gomez's issues in the race to represent California's 34th Congressional District, a Latino-majority territory spanning Koreatown, Boyle Heights, East Los Angeles, Glassell Park and adjacent neighborhoods.

Gonzales-Torres, who has worked part-time jobs as an academic counselor for formerly incarcerated students and at an affordable housing development, is backed by the Democratic Socialists of America and counts support from other national progressive organizations.

Over the last week, she campaigned at UC Berkeley alongside fellow progressive Rep. Ro Khanna (D-Fremont), appeared on left-wing streamer Hasan Piker's show and rallied in Los Angeles with Parkland, Fla., school shooting survivor and activist David Hogg.

Gonzales-Torres has linked the accusation against Gomez to a onetime ally of the politician's, former Rep. Eric Swalwell, a Bay Area Democrat who saw his campaign for governor derailed when several women came forward with allegations of impropriety. Swal-

[See **House,** A6]

Doubt over Bass' outside backers

Experts ask whether big-money groups supporting mayor are truly independent.

BY DAVID ZAHNISER

Solomon Rivera left a $272,000-a-year job advising Los Angeles Mayor Karen Bass this year. Months later, he was helping her out in a different way: running Unidos Con Karen Bass, an outside campaign committee supporting her reelection.

A lawyer for Unidos Con Karen Bass says there's nothing improper about Rivera's change in duties. Others disagree, saying an ethics investigation is warranted.

As an independent expenditure committee, Unidos Con Karen Bass is allowed to raise campaign donations in unlimited amounts. In exchange for that privilege, the committee cannot coordinate its activities with the mayor or her campaign.

Because Rivera was recently a high-level aide to Bass, he is presumed under city and state law to be coordinating with the mayor's campaign while running the pro-Bass Unidos committee, said Neama Rahmani, former director of enforcement for the city's Ethics Commission. That, in turn, would make the money spent by Unidos a contribution to the mayor's reelection campaign, and subject to the city's strict limit of $1,800 per donor, he said.

"The law is written to prevent these types of insiders who are not truly independent from going to I.E. committees," said Rahmani, who supervised investigations for the Ethics Commission from 2012 to 2014.

Rahmani, who is not supporting either candidate, said if he were still with the Ethics Commission, he would have launched an investigation into Unidos, which has spent about $1.1 million on digital ads and other campaign expenses.

Rivera, who spent three years as Bass' deputy chief of staff, didn't respond to in-

[See **Bass,** A7]

A $34-million school with zero students

LAUSD campus sits vacant and vandalized as enrollment shrinks

BY HOWARD BLUME



MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

A SIGN near the entrance to the Miramar campus rotates messages even though it closed in 2021.

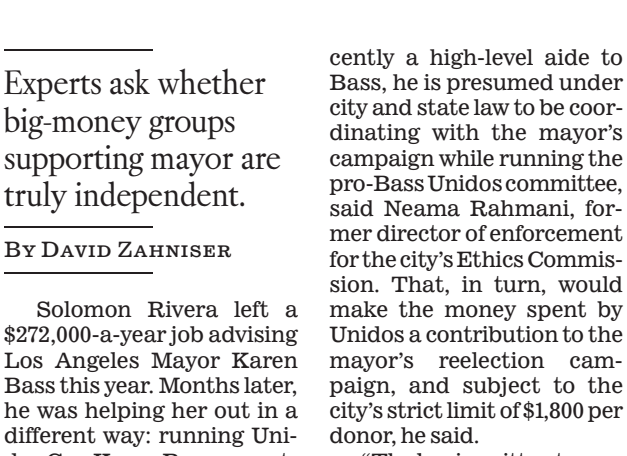
A modern, vacant and vandalized $34-million public school sits next to Los Angeles Unified School District headquarters — a campus paid for with taxpayer-financed bond money, but so burdened with debt and damage that it's not clear that anyone can afford to move in.

The compact, aesthetically striking campus is marred by widespread graffiti. Vandals have punched holes in floors, walls and ceilings over the last five years. Recent photos of the inside appear to show puddles and stains from water damage and char marks from fire.

The district is paying at least $20,000 a month in security and maintenance, and last year calculated having spent more than $1 million to secure and maintain the building.

The empty Miramar campus — informally named for its address of 1215 Miramar St. — stands as a parable for looming challenges as L.A. Unified leaders deter-

[See **Miramar,** A14]



MEG OLIPHANT NWSL

TAKING FLIGHT AT LAST

Gisele Thompson, center, and Angel City overcame years of adversity to become the NWSL's hottest club going into the playoffs. **SPORTS, B10**

Ballot counting appeal is denied

A district court hearing on a federal bid to block 20,000 state ballots is scheduled Tuesday. **CALIFORNIA, A7**

Anthropic's huge IPO is coming

Get the key details about the AI giant and its listing. **BUSINESS, A9**

Markets **A11**

Weather
Partly sunny.
L.A.Basin: 78/60. **B6**

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